

APM Project Management Qualification

Learner Study Pack



Reviews

Introduction

This section of the Learner Study Pack will cover the Reviews competence of the APM Project Management Qualification.

This section will enable you to gain an understanding of that reviews are one of the principal mechanisms to ensure the quality of deliverables, performance of the management process and the on-going viability of any project related work.

Learning objective and outcomes

Learning objective:

6. Understand reviews as a way of gathering information to provide an assessment on the status of a project and the ongoing viability of the work.

By the end of this activity, you should be able to:

6a) Understand the benefits of conducting reviews throughout the life cycle (including decision gates, benefits reviews and audits).

6b) Know the factors which would typically be reported on to help ensure successful project outcomes.

6c) Understand the importance of producing information and collecting data to inform decision making and communicate actions and decisions to stakeholders.

6d) Understand why activities may be re-planned after a review.

Study time

This section of the Learner Study Pack will take approximately 1 - 2 hours to complete.

Recommended resources

In addition to your Learner Study Pack, use the below references for more information on Reviews:

- APM Body of Knowledge Seventh edition 2.2.2 (Decision gate), 4.3.1 (Progress monitoring and reporting)
- APM (2013) What makes a good project reviewer? <https://www.apm.org.uk/blog/what-makes-a-good-project-reviewer/>
- APM (2012) Project Reviews, Assurance and the PMO <https://www.apm.org.uk/blog/project-reviews-assurance-and-the-pmo/>

Overview

Project reviews provide an independent perspective ensuring that important details aren't overlooked and that the project is progressing against the original plan and specifications.

They also enable project managers to adapt to the fluid requirements of any project, including allocating (or re-allocating) resources, staff and expertise.

Benefits of reviews

There are three key different types of reviews that can be held during the life cycle of a project and they provide different benefits.

Type	When	Benefits
Decision Gates	Linear – event driven and held at the end of each stage. Iterative – timebound and held at the end of each iteration.	Increased senior stakeholder involvement. Gain agreement from Project Sponsor and Governance Board. Ensure that project is on track and delivering benefits outlined in original business case.
Benefits Reviews	Held by the Project Sponsor during 'benefits realisation' phase – typically 6 – 12 months after project handover.	Checking that the project achieved the business benefits identified in the original business case. Determines and identifies actions or improvements needed to support the realisation of the benefits.
Audits	Regularly held by personnel independent of the project either at a set frequency, or when an issue is identified	Provide independent compliance assessment. Increase stakeholder confidence. Ensure that the project is following agreed governance and processes as defined in the project's quality management plans.

Reporting factors

There are several factors that should be reported on, as part of the review process, to ensure successful project outcomes, including:

- Progress against the schedule.
- Project spend – actual against planned.
- Earned value- tracking project spend and understanding the value of the work achieved.
- Audit findings and number of non-conformances.
- Risks and issues.

Decision making and information

For a review process to work, a combination of a broad perspective or 'Big Picture' view of the project must be combined with in-depth analysis and detailed evidence, as required.

This means that the production of information and its collation as data is crucial to allow appropriate decision-making and communication of those decisions.

Below are key elements of information and data that are vital to making project centric decisions:

Status reporting	Estimating the project	Risk identification	Problem solving and option appraisals	Availability of information	Knowledge and information management
• So that the project manager can better understand the status of the project in relation to cost, schedule and quality against the acceptance criteria in the project management plan (PMP).	• So that more realistic schedules and costs can be developed using past project data.	• So that the need for any subsequent corrective actions to be undertaken or the need for escalation can be determined.	• So that options and solutions to solve project problems and issues can be generated using past project experience.	• To inform the decision-making process at key points, such as gate reviews, by ensuring the relevant information is available in an appropriate format.	• To provide an understanding of when best to schedule quality assurance and quality control activities for the project by assessing what was done on past projects and by understanding the optimum times within a project life cycle to schedule these activities to maximise the findings.

Re-planning following reviews

After any review, there may be a need to re-plan project activities to ensure overall success. This is aided by progress monitoring and the creation of thorough and meaningful reports because of that monitoring.

Potential causes of re-planning may include:

- Achievement of planned scope doesn't meet the requirement.
- Motivation and satisfaction of the project team is low.
- Performance of contractors and/or relationships within supply chain are poor.
- Committed costs and cashflow exceeds original forecasts.
- Changes to the risk profile and/or impact on time and cost contingency are needed due to newly identified, or changed, risks.
- Communication with stakeholders is ineffective.

Scenario One:

As part of the renovation project at 'Snappy Appy', Ayo (the Founder/CEO) wants to ensure that everything is done to prevent details from being overlooked.

They know that this is not an area that they are particularly strong in and have asked Robin, the Finance Manager to be involved. Robin is a huge advocate for processes and procedures to make sure that actions are completed within agreed timeframes and to the agreed standard.

They have asked you to set up a system of reviews that will allow regular checks to be made ensuring that the renovation budget stays on time and on budget.

List all the potential decision gates that could be involved in the duration of the renovation project.

When would you hold the Benefit Reviews and who would be involved?

What information will you need to ensure is available to Robin for their regular project audits?

Scenario Two:

Robin is enjoying the responsibility that has been given to them by Ayo to oversee the review process for the renovation project. This is the biggest task that they have been asked to be involved in since joining the company and as such, they are looking to make a big impact!

Robin wants to focus on attention to detail and the quality of information within the review process. They'd like to provide a regular report to the senior leadership team to ensure that they are aware of the progress of the project.

Draft the format that you would recommend for the regular senior leadership report.

Ensure that you include all the key factors and information topics.

How will you distribute/present the report to ensure the senior leadership team's continued enthusiasm for the project?

Scenario Three:

As Robin always wants to be prepared and can be seen as risk adverse at times, they are already anticipating that the renovation project could go over budget.

Although you've told them that at this early stage it is impossible to tell whether the project could go over budget and by how much, they have asked you to start thinking about the mitigations that could be made following the first review and subsequent report.

What actions could you introduce into the project that would either prevent it from going over budget, or help to bring it back under budget?

Learning review questions

Before you attempt the exam practice questions in the next section, we recommend you review your learning to quickly see which aspects you don't understand or can't remember as well.

It will also boost your confidence by confirming what you have learnt and your demonstrated ability to apply that knowledge, so that you are ready to practise for the exam.

Here are some questions you may wish to answer to review your learning from the Reviews section:

- What will be the benefits of undertaking reviews at decision dates in both a linear life cycle and an iterative life cycle?
- When would you recommend that benefits reviews are undertaken over the course of a project, why is it important these are undertaken and who might be involved in those reviews?
- In a project review, one of the important factors that should be reported on is project actual spend against the planned spend. Why is this important?

Exam practice questions

6.1 Why is it important to conduct reviews of your project throughout its lifecycle?
(1 mark)

- a. To ensure stakeholders are continuously informed.
- b. To evaluate project performance.
- c. To report on progress to the project team.
- d. To determine the RAG rating for the project.

6.2 During a project review, which of these would best demonstrate how a project is performing?
(1 mark)

- a. The progress of the project's communication plan
- b. The actual costs versus forecast costs
- c. The number of resources assigned to the project
- d. The project's responses to risk so far

6.3 What is the primary purpose of project reviews in assessing the status and ongoing viability of a project?
(1 mark)

- a. To identify issues with the project management approach.
- b. To gather information for decision-making and communicate actions to stakeholders.
- c. To evaluate the benefits the project has delivered to establish if the objectives have been met.
- d. To implement solutions to project-level issues.

6.4 A project review reveals that activities need to be re-planned.

Which of the following would not contribute to the need to re-plan?
(1 mark)

- a. Identification of new risks.
- b. The governance structure.
- c. Application of lessons learned from previous phases.
- d. Approved changes to the project scope.

6.5 You have just finished a phase of work within your project and reached a decision gate.

What are three questions that should be answered ahead of a decision gate?
(3 marks)

What are two benefits of decision gates?
(2 marks)

6.6 You are working on a project which involves migrating to new hardware. It is critical that the migration is complete before the contract with the existing hardware supplier ends.

The project is currently behind schedule, partly due to internal specialist resources being busy on other work, and confusion amongst stakeholders about why the project is so urgent. The project's budget is showing an underspend, and no contingency has been spent so far.

You are preparing for a schedule review meeting with your project stakeholders.

What two pieces of information should you share with your stakeholders at this meeting?
(2 marks)

What three actions could you suggest to help the project get back on track?
(3 marks)

6.7 In order to make sure that a project is going well, project reviews report on a number of different factors.

For example, the project manager can prepare a report on _____ **(a)** _____ to track project spend against the value of the work achieved so far.

Although reports and reviews can vary, the three key factors that should always be considered are _____ **(b)** _____.

(2 marks)

(a)

1. Earned value
2. Budget
3. Benefits
4. Project deliverables

(b)

1. Risks, issues and change
2. Quality, time and cost
3. Benefits, budget and quality
4. Risks, time and cost

6.8 State two reasons why you may need to re-plan the activities on your project following a project review.

(2 marks)

Exam practice answers

Question	Answer / Mark scheme
6.1	B
6.2	B
6.3	B
6.4	B
6.5	1 mark for each valid question, 3 marks available in total, for example: • What has been achieved? • What is required for the next stage • What are the key decisions to be made? • Is the business case still viable? 1 mark for each valid benefit, 2 marks available in total, for example, but not limited to: • Structured decision making • More effective risk management • Supports resource allocation • Ensures continued alignment with business objectives • Supports stakeholder engagement • Checks quality of deliverables delivered so far • Checks that the project is on track / that progress is as planned
6.6	1 mark for each of the pieces of information, 2 marks available in total. For example, but not limited to: • Overall project progress against baseline project schedule • Budget against money spent so far • Quality of project deliverables • Resource allocation • Resource requirements • Risk / issue log 1 mark for each action, 3 marks available in total. For example, but not limited to: • Spend some of the contingency to hire external specialists and keep project on track. • Re-allocate internal specialist resources to help support the priorities. • Carry out communications to stakeholders on why the project is urgent / clarify with stakeholders why project is urgent and help prioritise. • Negotiate with the existing hardware supplier for an extension to the contract.
6.7	(a) 1 (b) 2
6.8	1 mark for each correct reason (a total of 2 marks available) for example: • New risks have been identified / existing risks have changed. • Project is not performing / scope is not being delivered on schedule / deliverables not being delivered to required quality. • Motivation / satisfaction of project team members is low. • Satisfaction of stakeholders is low / communication with stakeholders is poor. • Poor performance of suppliers / contractors. • Resource availability has changed. • Budget is not on track / costs or cash flow are above original forecasts.